

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 56 Summary

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This lesson teaches learners how to simplify Spanish sentence construction by using prepositions followed by infinitives (the unconjugated verb). This technique is especially helpful for adult learners who want to speak more fluidly and avoid conjugation delays in real-time conversations.

1. Strategy: Reduce the Need for Conjugation

One effective way to improve conversational speed is by building sentences that allow for the use of infinitives after prepositions and prepositional phrases. These plug-and-play constructions reduce the mental load of conjugating multiple verbs and give learners more time to think during conversation.

2. Key Construction: *Al + infinitive*

This structure means "upon doing something."

Examples:

- *Al llegar a casa, me acosté.* – Upon arriving home, I went to bed.
- *Al terminar el informe, se lo envié al jefe.* – Upon finishing the report, I sent it to my boss.
- *Al ver a mi amigo, lo saludé.* – Upon seeing my friend, I waved at him.

Note: Even though the English equivalent uses a present participle ("arriving," "finishing"), Spanish always uses the infinitive form after *al*.

3. More Prepositions That Take the Infinitive

- **Antes de + infinitive** – Before doing something
 - *Antes de salir, compré pan.* – Before leaving, I bought bread.
 - *Antes de acostarme, vi una película.* – Before going to bed, I watched a movie.
- **Después de + infinitive** – After doing something

- *Después de ver la película, me acosté.* – After watching the movie, I went to bed.
 - **En vez de + infinitive / En lugar de + infinitive** – Instead of doing something
 - *En vez de trabajar, decidí descansar.* – Instead of working, I decided to rest.
 - *En lugar de estudiar, fui a la playa.* – Instead of studying, I went to the beach.
 - **Sin + infinitive** – Without doing something
 - *Ella se fue sin despedirse.* – She left without saying goodbye.
 - *Me comí la pizza sin calentarla.* – I ate the pizza without heating it.
 - **Para + infinitive** – In order to do something
 - *Salimos temprano para llegar a tiempo.* – We left early in order to arrive on time.
 - *Compré flores para decorar la casa.* – I bought flowers to decorate the house.
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4. Subject Change Exception with *para que* + subjunctive

If the subject changes between the two clauses, use *para que* followed by the subjunctive instead of *para + infinitive*.

Example:

- *Apagué la luz para que los niños durmieran.* – I turned off the light so the children could sleep.
(Two subjects: I turned off the light; the children sleep.)

In this case, *durmieran* is in the imperfect subjunctive due to the past tense and the subject change.

5. Reflexive Verbs and Pronoun Placement

With reflexive verbs in these constructions, the reflexive pronoun attaches to the infinitive and must match the subject.

Examples:

- *Antes de acostarme, vi una película.* – Before going to bed, I watched a movie.
 - *Antes de acostarte, cepíllate los dientes.* – Before going to bed, brush your teeth.
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Conclusion

These constructions offer an efficient way to speak Spanish without pausing to conjugate

multiple verbs. They are especially useful for narrating events, forming polite suggestions, or describing sequences of actions. Mastering these prepositional phrases will make your Spanish sound more fluid and natural. If a subject change occurs, remember to use *para que* with the subjunctive instead of *para + infinitive*.